BBarters
Don't be users, be barters.

Possessive De

De + Definite Article + Noun

To indicate possession, use **"de" + definite article** before the second noun.

Contractions:

de + le = du
de + les = des

Français	English
Le panneau **du** chien	The dog's basket.
Le livre **de l**'étudiant	The student's book.

* We do not use the definite articles before the proper nouns while expressing possession

Français	English
La guitare **de** Chris Martin	The guitar of Chris Martin
Les chaussures **de** Michael Jordan	The shoes of Michael Jordan
La marque **de** Louis Vuitton	The brand of Louis Vuitton

* We do not use the definite articles before possessive adjectives/ demonstrative adjectives.

Français	English
J'ai les clés **de ta** voiture.	I have got your car keys.
Les photos **de mes** enfants	The photos of my kids.
Les citoyens **de notre** pays	The citizens of our country.

Descriptive De

To provide description for the first noun, we use “de” followed directly by the second descriptive noun

Français	English
les ingrédients dans la nourriture **de** bébé	The ingredients in baby food
les files **d’**attente	The waiting line
les bouteilles **d'**eau	The water bottles

Difference between Possessive De and Descriptive De

Possessive ‘de’ is followed by definite articles (except in proper nouns & possessive adjectives/ demonstrative adjectives). However, descriptive ‘de’ is directly followed by nouns without any definite articles in between.

To differentiate, one must remember the context of usage in the sentence. When the second noun after “de” is in possession of the first noun (Le drapeau du Canada = The flag of Canada) then it is possessive ‘de’.

On the other hand when the noun after “de” is used to describe the first noun then it is descriptive de (Le drapeau de Canada = Canadian Flag)

Possessive de	Meaning	Descriptive de	Meaning
Le livre de l’étudiant	The book of the student	Le livre d’étudiant	The student book
La maison des retraités	The house of the retired people	La maison de retraite	Retirement home
Le panneau du chien	The basket of the dog	Le panneau de chien	The basket for the dog
La dissolution du mariage	The dissolution of the marriage	La demande de mariage.	The marrige proposal

The difference is contextual and not absolute in every case. Descriptive “de” can also sometimes be replaced by an adjective.

E.g the following two mean the same thing: (Canadian flag)

Le drapeau de Canada
Le drapeau canadien